KAAN

SLIDE 1

Hi, I’m Kaan, and this is Caner. Today we’ll look at how we recognize brands without their names. Sometimes a color, a shape, or a package is enough. In daily life, we rarely read every logo on a shelf. Instead, we spot familiar bottles and colors. We’ll explore four famous examples to see how this works.

SLIDE 2

Let’s start with a quick quiz. Here are four plain colors: red, yellow, turquoise, and blue. There are no names and no shapes here. Color alone is not always enough to identify a brand. Many different companies share red or blue. Without a shape or context, not everyone will recognize them.

SLIDE 3

Now look at these new clues. Here is a black bottle silhouette, plus packaging textures from three items. We see fry packaging, a gift box, and a bag. Adding a physical shape changes everything. Shape turns a plain color into a real product. The choices become much clearer right away.

SLIDE 4

Here is the reveal: Coca-Cola, McDonald’s, Tiffany, and IKEA. We did not know these brands from birth. Instead, we learned them by seeing them again and again. We spot them in shops, ads, and street signs. Over time, a familiar shape becomes an easy shortcut. That is how these brands stick in our memory.

SLIDE 5

We often hear that red creates hunger and blue builds trust. But a color does not mean the same thing to everyone. With brands, we learn these links by seeing the same colors again and again. So using a color consistently matters. Caner will show you some examples.

SLIDE 6

Our first case study is Coca-Cola. In the early 1900s, sodas used plain glass bottles. Local competitors copied them very easily. Paper labels also peeled off in cold water coolers. In 1915, Coca-Cola asked designers for help. They wanted a bottle you could recognize by touch in the dark.

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The Root Glass Company in Indiana answered the challenge. While researching, designers saw a sketch of a cocoa bean. It had rounded ribs and curved lines. Cocoa was not in the recipe, but the grooves inspired them. Alexander Samuelson patented this fluted shape on November 16, 1915.

SLIDE 8

Here we compare a photo-derived silhouette with the 1915 patent drawing. Both images are in black and white. There is no red color and no brand name. Yet the curved bottle remains easy to spot. This shows that shape works as a clue all by itself. You do not need color to identify this container.

SLIDE 9

Our second case study is McDonald’s. The logo is visible here. But imagine covering it. The red box and fries still give us clues. The curved red carton and yellow fries work together. Not everyone will recognize it, of course. Still, packaging shape and color support each other well.

SLIDE 10

McDonald’s also shows how visual clues adapt. In 2009, some European restaurants changed red backgrounds to green. The golden arches stayed the same. In 2018, Canadian billboards used cropped pieces of the arches. They pointed drivers toward nearby restaurants. These ads used parts of a familiar logo, not color alone.

SLIDE 11

Our third case study is Tiffany and Co. They built strong recognition around one signature color. In the 1800s, the founder picked robin’s-egg blue for a catalogue. Soon, the blue box with a white satin ribbon appeared. People learned to connect this color with luxury jewelry gifts. The box itself became as famous as the jewelry.

SLIDE 12

Tiffany protected this blue box through strict presentation rules. An old 1906 report said you could never buy an empty box. It only came with a real jewelry purchase. That is Tiffany’s own account, not independent research. Still, it shows how carefully they protected the packaging.

SLIDE 13

To keep the color consistent, Tiffany worked with Pantone in 2001. They created a custom standard called 1837 Blue. The color on this screen is only an approximation. Tiffany also trademarked the color for packaging in 1998. That rule applies to luxury boxes, not every blue product.

SLIDE 14

Our fourth case study is IKEA. We all know their blue and yellow buildings today. But standardizing these colors took many years. In 1984, IKEA published its first brand manual. From 1991, they built blue warehouse stores with yellow signs. Now, back to Kaan.

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Thanks, Caner. IKEA created another famous clue: the blue FRAKTA bag. In 1986, shoppers got tired carrying heavy goods. IKEA tested yellow bags in 1989, but checkout got confusing. So yellow bags stayed inside for borrowing. Blue bags were sold to take home. That durable bag became a familiar household clue.

SLIDE 16

What do these examples teach us about design? First, color alone is rarely enough. Many big companies use the same basic colors. Red is used by Coca-Cola, Target, and McDonald’s. Yellow is shared by IKEA, Shell, and DHL. Without context, one color can suggest several brands.

SLIDE 17

This is why visual clues work best together. A plain bottle outline could be any drink. A solid red square could mean many brands. But when you pair shape with color, recognition becomes easy. Not everyone will spot every clue instantly. Still, multiple clues support each other during shopping.

SLIDE 18

Our next lesson is about the risk of redesigns. Design teams often want to change packaging for new trends. But shoppers rely on quick visual habits in store aisles. If a company changes colors or shapes too fast, customers get confused. Protecting familiar clues keeps existing buyers happy.

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Here are three practical tips for designers. First, build clear shapes that work in black and white. Second, pair colors with unique packages and fonts. Third, stay consistent over long periods of time. You can evolve cues carefully, but test before changing them. Consistency turns simple designs into lasting memory shortcuts.

SLIDE 20

To wrap up, logos still matter at the final moment. But in crowded places, shapes and colors catch our attention first. Bottles, fry cartons, and gift boxes guide us without words. Thank you very much for your time. Caner and I are happy to take any questions.